# HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN JORDAN

## INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In Jordan, almost everything turns on water, because it is one of the most water-scarce countries on earth, and the destructive projects that most threaten its future are those that mine, waste, or gamble with a resource it cannot replace. Jordan has less renewable fresh water per person than almost any other nation in the entire world, far below even the recognised threshold of absolute scarcity; most of its people receive piped running water only a few hours in a given week; and its water crisis deepens with every passing year of population growth, refugee influx, and worsening drought. The gravest harms here are not smoke-belching factories but water projects gone wrong: the mining of the ancient, non-renewable **Disi aquifer**, some thirty thousand years old and shared with a neighbouring state, pumped for a few decades of relief at the cost of an irreplaceable store; the over-pumping that killed the **Azraq wetlands** a generation ago; the diversion and mineral extraction draining the **Dead Sea** by a metre a year and pockmarking its shore with sinkholes that swallow roads and homes; and the vast, costly, risky water mega-projects launched in desperation. There is no landmark community victory to point to, and this is a kingdom with real red lines. But water is Jordan's binding constraint, and that gives real ground.

A community in Jordan opposing a water-destroying project works with real, if constrained, tools, all grounded in water and worked carefully within the system. The distinctive lever is the **water-security argument**: in the world's most water-scarce country, where water is the state's own foremost national-security concern, a project that mines, wastes, or gambles with water is self-defeating on the state's own terms — a case the state itself cannot easily dismiss. Jordan's **own water strategy and technical institutions** are a real standard and channel the state can be held to. The **undeniable science of depletion** — the finite fossil Disi aquifer, the dying Dead Sea, the lost Azraq wetlands — grounds the case in evidence no one can deny. Major water projects must reckon with **environmental assessment**. The **international funders and partners** who support Jordan's water sector carry safeguards and leverage. And, because refusal alone fails a desperate country, the case is strongest when it shows that **the need can be met by better means** — efficiency, reuse, demand management — than mining or gambling an irreplaceable resource. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. Jordan faces a genuine and desperate water crisis with few good options, and the state mines fossil water and builds costly desalination not from indifference but from need. Much of the harm is transboundary and beyond Jordan's sole control. And the political space is limited: this is a kingdom with real red lines around the monarchy, the security services, and certain political matters, so — though water advocacy is generally more tolerated than overt political dissent — the work must be careful, technical, and within the system, framed around water security and the shared interest, never around challenging authority, and protecting everyone involved. And there is no landmark victory to point to. So the honest prize is a water-destroying project scrutinised, reconsidered, or improved, and the case made for the better alternative — on the state's own paramount concern — not an open defeat of a desperate state's water plans. Above all, keep it to water, and protect the people.

### The Whole Strategy in One Idea

You cannot defeat a desperate state's water plans by opposition, nor safely challenge a kingdom's authority. What you can do is make the case the state's own survival demands: show that a project mining, wasting, or gambling water is self-defeating in the world's most water-scarce country, ground it in the undeniable science of depletion, hold the state to its own water strategy, invoke the international funders' safeguards — and, above all, show that the need can be met by better means than destroying an irreplaceable resource, all carefully and within the system.

### Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Jordan is a desperate, constrained setting, and honesty about that is the first discipline. The water crisis is real and the options few; the state mines fossil water and builds costly desalination from need, not indifference; much of the harm is transboundary and beyond Jordan's sole control; and the political space is limited by real red lines. This is not a fight you win by opposition or confrontation. It is a careful, technical, within-system effort worked on the state's own paramount concern — water security — whose realistic prize is a project scrutinised, reconsidered, or improved, and a better alternative made the case. Keep it strictly to water, and protect everyone.

## HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

### Who Actually Decides

Power in a kingdom rests with the monarchy and the government, but the decisions a careful, technical effort can reach run through the water sector itself: the **Ministry of Water and Irrigation and its technical institutions**, which set and administer the water strategy; the **environmental authorities and the assessment process**; the **international funders and partners** who support the water sector; and the **scientists and technical experts** who hold the depletion data. These, engaged strictly on water and within the system, are who can be reached. Map them before spending a week on it.

### How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

A water project — an aquifer scheme, a desalination or conveyance mega-project, a diversion — advances by state decision, resting on the state's water strategy and, for major projects, an environmental assessment. The entry point is the water-security case: a technical argument that the project mines, wastes, or gambles the resource the state most needs to protect, and that a better alternative exists. For internationally funded projects, the entry point is also the funders' safeguards. Enter always technically, within the system, and on water.

### Follow the Money and the Permissions

Follow the water: what a project mines, wastes, or gambles — the fossil aquifer drawn down, the Dead Sea drained, the wetland lost — and how it strains the resource the state most needs. Follow the strategy: what Jordan's own water strategy commits to, and where the project departs from it. Follow the finance: which international funders back the project and what safeguards they carry. The leverage lies in the water-security argument, the state's own strategy, the science, and the funders' safeguards.

### Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Oversight runs through the water sector: the Ministry of Water and Irrigation and its strategy, the environmental authorities and the assessment process, the international funders and their safeguards, and the scientific and technical institutions. These are the channels a careful case engages — holding each, on the state's own paramount concern, to the water strategy, the science, and the safeguards.

## QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

No Jordanian effort openly defeats a desperate state's water plans, and honesty requires saying so — the crisis is real and the options few. What the water-security tools can deliver is a project scrutinised, reconsidered, or improved, and a better alternative made the case. The single most decisive move is **the water-security argument grounded in the undeniable science of depletion**, because in the world's most water-scarce country a project that squanders water is self-defeating on the state's own deepest priority, and because the science of the finite aquifer and the dying sea cannot be dismissed. The water-security argument is the distinctive lever; the state's own strategy the standard; the science the anchor; the funders' safeguards the external handle. The realistic prize is a water-destroying project reconsidered, and a better alternative advanced — pursued carefully and on water.

## STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Ask five questions. **What is the harm?** — the aquifer mined, the sea drained, the wetland lost, the water wasted or gambled. **How is it self-defeating?** — how it squanders the resource the state most needs. **What does the science show?** — the depletion data no one can deny. **Is there a better alternative?** — the efficiency, reuse, or demand management that meets the need without the harm. **Is it internationally funded?** — whose safeguards apply. Pick the harm where the water-security argument and the science give the clearest, safest handle, and a better alternative exists.

## STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Build the case in layers, technically and on water. **Layer one: the harm** — the aquifer, sea, or wetland the project mines, drains, or loses, and how it squanders the resource the state most needs, documented with the depletion science. **Layer two: the standard and the alternative** — the state's own water strategy the project departs from, the environmental assessment, and the better means that meet the need. **Layer three: the channel and the care** — which water, environmental, or funder body to reach, and the discipline of keeping everything on water, within the system, and never political, protecting everyone. A case built on the water-security argument and the undeniable science is one the state cannot easily dismiss on its own paramount concern.

## WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Gather the **harm record**: the depletion data — the finite Disi aquifer, the falling Dead Sea, the lost Azraq wetlands, the water squandered. Gather the **standard record**: the state's own water strategy, the environmental-assessment requirements. Gather the **alternative record**: the efficiency, reuse, and demand-management options that meet the need without the harm. Gather the **finance record**: the international funders and their safeguards. Gather the **care discipline**: confirm the work stays on water, within the system, technical, and protective of everyone.

## STEP 3: BUILDING THE TECHNICAL AND WATER COALITION

The coalition here is technical and water-focused, worked carefully. Build it from the **water scientists and technical experts** whose depletion data grounds the case; the **water-sector institutions and professionals** within the system; the **affected communities**, whose water is at stake, kept to the water question; and the **international funders and water partners** who carry safeguards. Frame everything around water security and the shared interest, never around challenging authority; protect individuals, especially those inside institutions or communities whose positions could be jeopardised; and keep strictly to water, away from the red lines.

## STEP 4: THE WATER-SECURITY ARGUMENT, THE SCIENCE & THE ALTERNATIVES — CONTESTING THE HARM CAREFULLY

Set expectations honestly: the levers are technical, within-system, and constrained, in a desperate and guarded state, so the prize is a project reconsidered and a better alternative advanced, not an open stop.

### The Water-Security Argument and the State's Strategy

The distinctive lever is the **water-security argument**: in the world's most water-scarce country, a project that mines, wastes, or gambles water is self-defeating on the state's own foremost concern. And Jordan's **own water strategy and technical institutions** are a standard the state can be held to. Press the harm as a threat to the water security the state most prizes.

### The Science of Depletion

The **undeniable science of depletion** — the finite fossil Disi aquifer, the dying Dead Sea, the lost Azraq wetlands — grounds the case in evidence no one can deny, and the **environmental assessment** is a further gate. Let the hard science of an irreplaceable resource being squandered carry the weight.

### The Alternatives and the International Support

Because refusal alone fails a desperate country, the case is strongest when it shows **the need can be met by better means** — efficiency, reuse, demand management — and the **international funders and partners** carry safeguards and leverage. Pursued together — the water-security argument and strategy, the science, and the better alternatives and funders — these levers press a water-destroying project toward reconsideration, on the state's own paramount concern.

## TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Tailor the case, always to water security. **For the water ministry**: here is a project that squanders the resource your strategy exists to protect, and a better alternative. **For the environmental authorities**: here is the assessment of an irreversible loss of water. **For the scientists**: here is the depletion data to carry. **For the international funders**: here is a project that fails your safeguards and mines an irreplaceable resource. **For the public**: here is the water we cannot replace, and the better way to secure it. **The golden rule**: ground everything in the water-security argument and the undeniable science, show the better alternative, keep it strictly on water and within the system, and protect everyone.

## STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media must be handled with care in a kingdom with red lines. Frame any attention strictly around **water security and the shared interest**: an irreplaceable resource being mined, wasted, or gambled, and the better way to secure it — never around challenging authority. Carry it through the technical, scientific, and water-sector channels more than through open confrontation. A few cautions govern everything: keep it strictly to water; frame it around the shared water security; protect everyone; stay clear of the red lines; and let the depletion science and the state's own strategy carry the weight.

## EMAILS & LETTERS

Keep every message technical, on water, within the system, and protective of everyone.

**8A — To the water ministry**: set out how the project squanders the water your strategy protects, and the better alternative, with the science.

**8B — To the environmental authority**: request the assessment of the project's irreversible water harm.

**8C — On the science**: present the depletion data — the aquifer, the sea, the wetlands — that grounds the case.

**8D — On the alternatives**: set out the efficiency, reuse, or demand management that meets the need without the harm.

**8E — To an international funder**: flag a project that fails your safeguards and mines an irreplaceable resource.

**8F — To a water scientist or institution**: request the technical assessment and data.

**8G — To the affected community**: set out the shared water stake and organise carefully around water.

**8H — To the technical public**: summarise the water-security case — strictly on water — and ask for attention, without exposing anyone.

## IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

**The first 48 hours**: assemble the depletion science and how the project squanders water; write the one-page water-security case and the better alternative; identify the channel — usually the water ministry, a scientist, or a funder. **The fastest-moving levers**: the water-security argument, the science of depletion, and the funders' safeguards. **Emergency action**: for an internationally funded project, the funders' safeguards; for any water project, the state's own strategy and the science. Throughout, keep it strictly on water and within the system, and protect everyone.

## WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

The field here is tilted by a desperate water crisis, few options, transboundary harm, and a kingdom's red lines. Recognise it and adjust the aim — not an open stop, but a project reconsidered and a better alternative advanced. Lean on the levers the tilt cannot easily dismiss: the water-security argument on the state's own paramount concern, the undeniable science, the state's own strategy, the funders' safeguards. And accept the honest limits — the state acts from need, much harm is transboundary, the space is guarded — while still pressing the water-security case and protecting everyone.

## WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO BENEFITS

Distinguish the ordinary tilt from capture — a costly, risky water mega-project steered to insiders, a scheme that enriches a few while squandering water, safeguards ignored. Where capture appears, respond only through the **technical and within-system channels**: the water-security argument, the science, the state's own strategy, the funders' safeguards. Never through anything political or near the red lines. **On safety and care**: this note matters throughout. Jordan is a kingdom with real red lines around the monarchy, the security services, and certain political matters; while water advocacy is generally more tolerated than overt political dissent, it must still be careful. Favour the technical, scientific, and institutional channels; frame the work around water security and the shared interest, never around challenging authority; protect those inside institutions or communities whose positions could be jeopardised; and keep strictly to water. Care is the first rule.

## INTEGRATION & TIMELINE: RUNNING ALL FIVE STEPS TOGETHER

The steps run in parallel, on water and within the system. The depletion science feeds the water-security argument, the strategy case, and the funders' safeguards at once; the technical and community coalition organises carefully alongside; any attention stays strictly on water throughout; the better alternative runs beneath it all. A rough timeline: **weeks one to four**, assemble the science and the water-security case; **months two to six**, engage the water ministry, the environmental authorities, the scientists, and the funders, and advance the alternative; **beyond**, press the reconsideration and the better path. The core discipline: water-security-grounded, science-anchored, within-system, and protective of everyone.

## FINAL ASSESSMENT

Jordan is a desperate, water-scarce, guarded ground, and this guide does not pretend otherwise. It does not claim a desperate state's water plans can simply be defeated, or that the options are many, or that a landmark victory exists — none of that is true, and the state acts from genuine need. What it claims is narrower and real: that in the world's most water-scarce country, a project that mines, wastes, or gambles water is self-defeating on the state's own foremost concern; that Jordan's own water strategy is a standard it can be held to; that the science of depletion — the finite Disi aquifer, the dying Dead Sea, the lost Azraq wetlands — is undeniable; that the international funders carry safeguards; and that, above all, the need can often be met by better means than destroying an irreplaceable resource. The levers are technical, within-system, and constrained, and the prize is a water-destroying project scrutinised, reconsidered, or improved, and a better alternative advanced — on the state's own paramount concern, not an open stop. For the world's most water-scarce country, that careful, water-security-grounded work — kept strictly to water, within the system, and protecting everyone — is not a lesser ambition. It is the responsible and effective one.